© 2026 Liam Hill
All rights reserved.

HELLAWAKE

Curse of a Broken World

Episode 1
CHASING GHOSTS

by Liam Hill

Episode 1
CHASING GHOSTS

The Dawn Horizon Division had called it routine. Inspect an old Skullborn outpost buried deep in the forest. In and out — no resistance expected.

Reever had wanted to believe that. Yet even as he told himself it was routine, a weight sat in his chest — the gnawing fear that a "simple" mission could still take the people he cared for away from him. Every assignment carried that shadow, a constant whisper of loss he could never silence.

✦ ✦ ✦

The bikes rumbled down the narrow forest trail, engines growling like restless beasts. Hoosier led with quiet certainty, his black-sky blue hoodie snapping in the wind, the steady warmth of his presence enough to steady Reever's nerves.

Behind him, Zack — better known as Flame — gripped his handlebars with barely contained energy, eyes alight with anticipation.

"*Man, if this place is as dead as they say, I'm gonna lose my mind!*" Flame bellowed over the roar. "*C'mon, tell me we're not wasting our time here!*" he shouted over the engines. "*We're hunting Skullborns, right? Not some abandoned shack!*"

"Stay sharp, Zack," Hoosier called back, his voice carrying that familiar, unshakable steadiness. "*Skullborn bases aren't abandoned without a reason.*"

Reever's lips twitched into a reluctant smile before his gaze returned to the narrowing trail. He didn't share Flame's appetite for battle. For him, every mission was a step toward understanding the forces that had torn his family apart.

✦ ✦ ✦

They rolled into the clearing, the forest giving way to a camp. Faded banners bearing the jagged insignia of the Skullborn fluttered weakly in the evening breeze. No voices. No movement.

Reever killed the engine, the sudden silence pressing in.

Too quiet.

Zack hopped off his bike, blades already in his hands. "*Hah! Told ya — graveyard duty. I'll take boring over nothing at all.*"

Hoosier scanned the perimeter, one hand resting on his sword. "*Don't get complacent. Something's wrong.*"

Reever crouched by a collapsed crate, fingers brushing against the weather-worn Skullborn crest. *Why would they leave this place untouched?*

A faint whistle cut through the air.

Pain bloomed along his cheekbone, hot and sharp. Blood welled instantly, dripping down his face.

"*Agh—!*" Reever jerked back, hand flying to his cheek.

"Reever!" Hoosier's voice snapped like a whip.

From the trees, shapes descended in a blur of movement. Death Grins—also known as the Skullborns—erupted from the canopy, their twisted smiles painted across their faces, weapons glinting in the fading light.

Hoosier's blade was already in motion, his strike clean and decisive as he intercepted the first attacker.

"Ambush! DEFENSIVE FORMATION!"

"*Yes!*" Flame roared, his grin stretching to match the enemies'. "*Now we're talking!*" He charged forward, his axe whirling in chaotic, precise arcs that mirrored his unrestrained personality.

Hoosier weaved through the swarm with razor precision, his sword carving clean lines of defense. Each motion was economical, his warm yet commanding voice cutting through the chaos as he barked instructions. Flame, in stark contrast, fought like a wildfire — unpredictable, explosive, every swing of his axe a whirlwind of brute strength and practiced aggression. The duo moved like a living storm, Hoosier anchoring the battle with discipline while Flame's untamed ferocity ripped through their enemies.

A Death Grin lunged low; Hoosier pivoted, blade tracing a swift, perfect arc that cut the attacker down.

"Reever! Report to HQ — NOW!"

Reever froze, heart hammering. *Leave them? No — if I go now… what if I never see them again? I can't lose anyone else… not again.*

"Reever!" Hoosier's voice cut through the chaos, commanding but not unkind.

"*Go. We can handle this. The Division needs the intel.*"

Zack parried another strike, shouting over the clash of steel, "*Bro, MOVE IT! We've got your back!*"

Reever hesitated for one breath, his fear clawing at him — then bolted.

I have to trust them… please, don't let this be the last time I see you both.

✦ ✦ ✦

The forest blurred past in streaks of green and gold. By the time he reached the metro station, the sky was burning orange, the last light of day sinking beneath the horizon.

He parked the bike, lungs burning, and hurried onto the platform — and froze.

Not a soul in sight. No waiting passengers. No staff.

Weird… where is everyone? A cold unease crept down his spine. *Stations aren't supposed to be this empty…*

The train arrived, its metallic groan breaking the silence. Reever boarded, glancing at the deserted carriage. He sank into a seat, exhaling shakily. The carriage was empty, the hum of the engine the only sound.

He leaned his head back against the cold window, the day's events pressing down on him. His cheek throbbed in time with his heartbeat, but the weight in his chest came from more than pain.

Hoosier, Flame… hold on.

Reever reached into his jacket and pulled out a small, creased photograph. Three smiling faces stared back: himself, Liam, and Naira — captured in a moment of warmth just hours before the day everything changed. His grip tightened, knuckles whitening.

A single, heavy drop of blood fell from the gash on his cheek, landing directly over Liam's eye. It bloomed like a dark, jagged flower across the glossy paper, the crimson petals spreading until his brother's gaze was completely obscured. Reever stared at the stain, his chest tightening as the red ink of his reality swallowed the last clear image of his past.

I can't lose anyone else. Not again.

✦ ✦ ✦

The rhythmic clatter of wheels over rails lulled him into a haze, but as the final station neared, unease prickled along his spine.

Then the world exploded.

A thunderous blast ripped through the evening calm, the train shrieking as metal twisted and crumpled. Reever was thrown against a seat, the air filling with smoke and burning sparks.

No one else on board… Thank god.

He kicked out a shattered window, dragging himself onto the wreckage-strewn track.

Through the haze, a lone figure emerged.

The assassin walked with a chilling purpose, one hand loosely gripping a single, curved blade that caught the fading light. His eyes, cold and unwavering, fixed on Reever as he tilted the blade, a slow, deliberate motion that promised death.

Reever wiped blood from his face, planting his feet. He lowered his center of gravity, hand slipping to the hilt of his sword. Every muscle tensed, his breathing steadying into the rhythm of combat.

"*Who the hell are you now? Just leave me alone for once… You messed with the wrong guy — or should I say — the wrong demon.*"

The assassin slid one foot forward, blade angled low in a duelist's stance. Sparks flared as steel rasped against steel; Reever had drawn his sword, raising it in a firm two-handed guard.

For a heartbeat, the world stilled — then they moved.

Steel met steel in a clash that rang across the ruined platform. Reever fought with raw determination, but fatigue dragged at his limbs, his earlier wounds screaming with every movement.

The assassin pressed forward with relentless precision, each strike forcing Reever back until his heel caught on twisted metal. He stumbled, breath ragged, arms trembling.

A savage kick sent him sprawling against the wreckage.

The assassin advanced, raising his blade for the killing blow —

and the world cut to black.

✦ ✦ ✦

Back in the forest (near the camp), Hoosier wiped the blood from his sword, the *black-sky blue* fabric of his hoodie spattered crimson. The captured Death Grin prisoner shook violently, terror stark in his wide eyes.

"*I don't know... anything about it... please... just let me go...*"

Hoosier studied him for a moment, gaze unreadable.

Zack wiped blood from his axe. "*So our work's done here? Prepare to return?*"

"*Yeah,*" Hoosier replied, leveling his sidearm. "*Except one last deed.*"

The gunshot echoed through the forest.

✦ ✦ ✦

WATCH THE ANIMATED EPISODE

► https://youtu.be/VeZK6KsbkXA?si=hymfQTOBUh_AvcQP

Scan the QR code below to watch:

More episodes coming soon.

✦ ✦ ✦